

GITCRAFT DESIGNCRAFT · GAME DESIGN BRIEF

TIDEBREAKERS

World & Voyage Design Bible

Making TIDEBREAKERS one living pirate adventure.

Fourteen characters developed, a 13-step first voyage redesigned, and a dinghy-to-pirate-ship ladder. Islands, ports, caves and treasure are tied into one legend. Every proposal comes in Conservative, Ambitious and Wild Card tiers, with its gameplay impact, implementation and tradeoffs.

v1.0 · 2026-11-05 · assessed at commit 5766ca5
Authoritative brief for the next implementation pass

READ ME FIRST

How to use this bible

This bible is the authoritative design brief for the next implementation passes on TIDEBREAKERS. It was written after reading the whole repository: the data in src/data, the game loop in src/game, the UI copy in src/ui, the voice lines in src/audio/pack.ts and every docs/ pass report. A DESIGNCRAFT assessment provided the measured baseline. Nothing in the game was changed to write it.

THE RULES

- **Authority:** if this bible and an older doc disagree on a design question, this bible wins. On a fact about the current code, the code wins, so fix the bible.
- **Preserve:** every existing id, mechanic, save field and test stays. New content is added beside the old, and retired steps migrate.
- **Tiers:** every area has three proposals. CONSERVATIVE fits in one PR and only changes data and copy. AMBITIOUS adds a system. WILD CARD is a prototype behind a ?wild= flag.
- **Recommended path:** build the Conservative tier of all five areas first (Phase 1). Then build the Ambitious items marked RECOMMENDED (Phase 2). The Wild Cards stay prototypes until playtests justify them (Phase 3).
- **Done means:** npm test and tests/e2e/play.cjs pass, the DESIGNCRAFT re-run meets the targets on the Acceptance page, and the live build shows the change.

HOW PROPOSALS ARE TAGGED

CONSERVATIVE

One PR. Data, copy and small art. Low risk. Build first.

AMBITIOUS

A new system or content set. Medium risk. Phase 2, where marked RECOMMENDED.

WILD CARD

A bold bet. Prototype behind ?wild=. Ships only after a playtest.

EVIDENCE TAGS

EXISTS: in the code today, cited as file:line at 5766ca5. **PROPOSED / NEW**: not in the game yet. Claims about how players will feel are inferred design judgements until a PLAYCRAFT pass or playtest measures them.

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01 · DIAGNOSIS

What exists, measured

TIDEBREAKERS already has a strong world. It has a drowned county, three regions, ten salvage sites, three settlements, raiders, living green, 13 upgrade slots across three vessels, and boats that show every part you fit. What it lacks is connective tissue. The systems work, but they don't talk to each other, and its people barely speak.

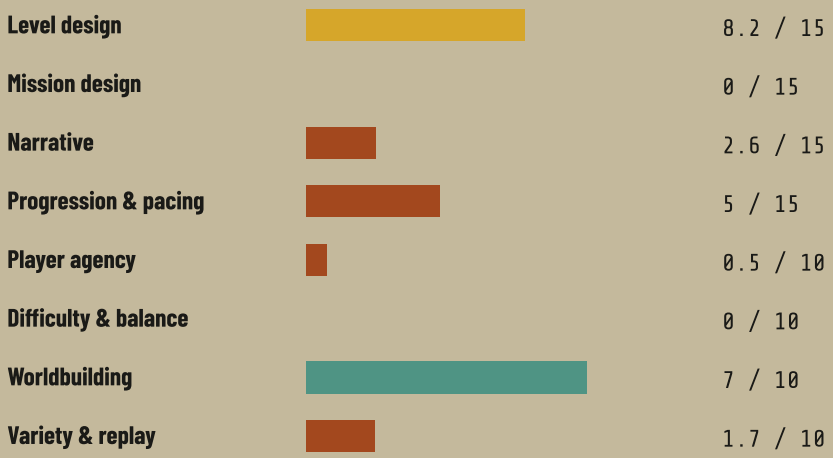
INVENTORY AT COMMIT 5766CA5

Regions	3: The Drift, The Sunken Reach, The Stormwall `src/data/world.ts:74`
Islands	5 walkable: Driftholm, Turtle Atoll, Lantern Rock, Gull Shoal, Canopy Rise `src/data/world.ts:92`
Settlements	3 with services: Driftholm, Rooftop Hollow, Rig Helios `src/data/world.ts:315`
Outposts	6 set-dressing sites, no services: Gullstep, Tin Can Rest, Last Call, Rustfang Hold, the Stripping Yard, Going Under `src/data/world.ts:425`
Salvage sites	10, each with a winch mini-game, respawn and first-haul finds `src/data/world.ts:355`
Treasure maps	2: The Turtle's Belly, Redfinch's Sun Hoard (2 fragments) `src/data/world.ts:197`
Vessels	3: Patchwork Skiff (id dinghy), Scrap Trimaran (sloop), Ironwake Expedition Cat `src/data/ship.ts:84`
Upgrades	19 across 13 slots; only 6 slots have a tier 2 `src/data/ship.ts:101`
Characters	14 named: 6 crew and 8 settlement NPCs `src/data/crew.ts:25, src/ui/ui.ts:92`
Guided content	First Voyage, 13 steps, then the Captain's Log, 10 goals `src/data/progress.ts:53, :78`
Milestones	11, rewarding 1,325 gold and 6 cosmetics in total `src/data/progress.ts:17`
Caves	None. No cave place, landmark or interior exists `src/data/world.ts:5`

DESIGNCRAFT ASSESSMENT

25 / 100

ceiling 85 · coverage 40% · confidence low



`DESIGNCRAFT 1.0 · method d98e718b8f0c · 25 / 100 · ceiling 85 · coverage 40%`

DESIGNCRAFT assessment at commit 5766ca5: 25 / 100, ceiling 85, coverage 40%, confidence low. Worldbuilding is the only category at its ceiling. Mission and difficulty score 0 because no mission data exists to measure, so the score reflects missing structure, not bad work. Correction from a source read: DESIGNCRAFT reported the 14 characters as having zero lines. It missed VOICE_LINES (src/audio/pack.ts:11) and the inline barks in game.ts/ui.ts. The true count is on the Cast page. The conclusion stands: no character has more than 6 lines or a single story beat.

01 · DIAGNOSIS

Six reasons it feels like systems

01
Systems, not a story
Salvage, treasure, crew, upgrades and settlements each work on their own, but none hands the player to another. The only thread is a reward-gold Captain's Log.

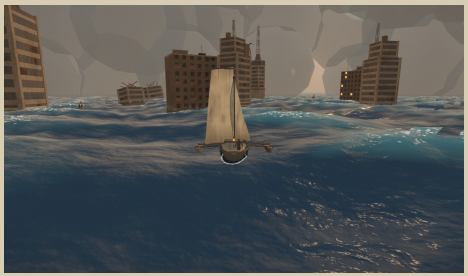
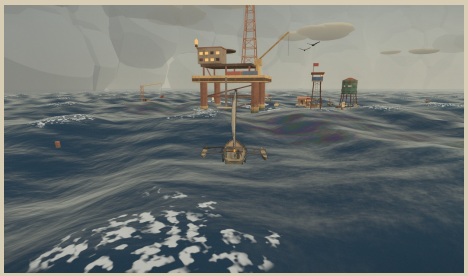
02
Mute people
14 named characters share about 40 lines. Mara Okonkwo has a pitch and nothing else. The 8 NPCs share three generic townsfolk models (src/world/environment.ts:584).

03
A tutorial, not a voyage
The First Voyage is 13 strictly linear steps. 4 of them are menus or shops. The game's signature verb, SALVAGE, never appears in it.

04
One road
The Captain's Log always shows exactly one next goal. Agency scores 0.5 / 10: there are no choices with consequences anywhere in the data.

05
A thin legend
Redfinch, the Wren and the Last Summit are the seeds of a pirate legend, but they live in two item names, one map and one log line: 'To be continued…'.

06
Empty quarters
19 of 36 map cells hold nothing to find. The north-west, between Rooftop Hollow and Canopy Rise, is 6 of 9 empty.


Real frames from the built game (creative/design-bible/source/capture.cjs): Rooftop Hollow · Old Meridian · Rig Helios · Rustfang Hold. The places are rich; nobody in them speaks.

02 · IDENTITY

Pirates after the flood

TIDEBREAKERS is a pirate game set after the flood. Its pirates are salvagers, rovers and raiders, the apocalyptic-pirate survivors the README describes. They fly patched colours, keep articles, bury what they can't carry and race each other for the old world. That makes 'pirate' a culture inside the drowned world rather than a theme pasted over it.

The boat is the game

Every upgrade is a part you can see on the boat. Progression is something you look at, not a number. (Existing, README.)

Green means alive

Living plants are the rarest thing in the world and the only saturated green. Keep green reserved: the tests already enforce it.

Everything salvaged, everything fought over

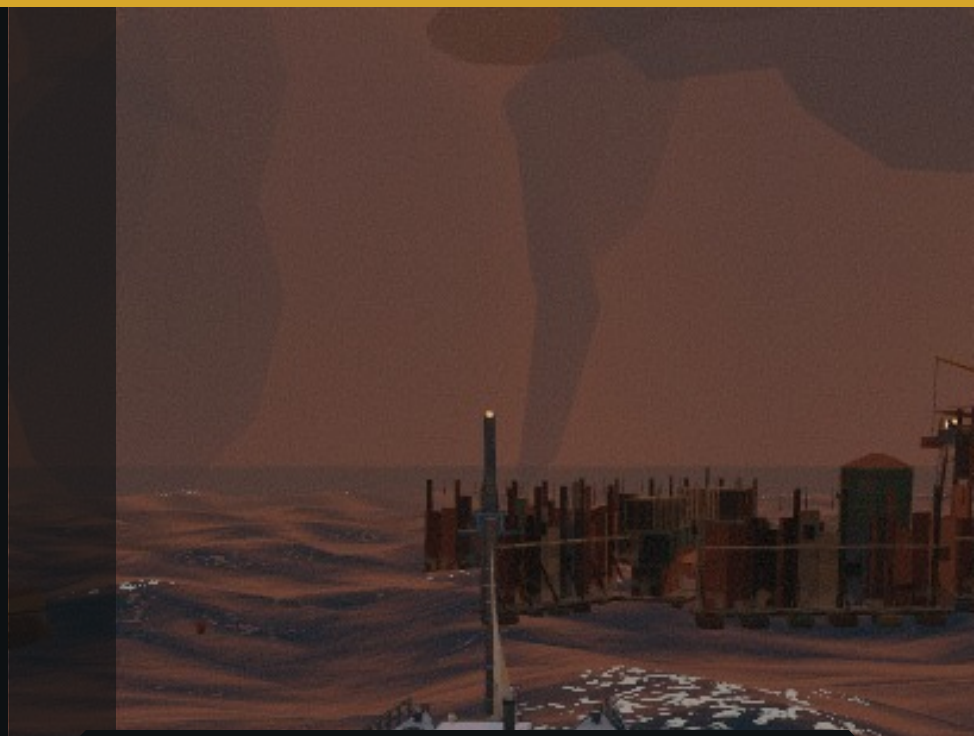
Every object has a past owner. Treasure is the old world, and someone always wants it back.

People make ports

NEW: every place you can dock has a face, a want and a reason to come back. A port without a person is just a shop.

Follow the wake

NEW: one legend, Redfinch and the Wren, threads every region together, so exploration always points somewhere.



THE PIRATE VOCABULARY

Articles: the crew's contract. Each recruit signs on with a line and a share.

Colours: your flag. Odessa sews them; milestones and renown earn them.

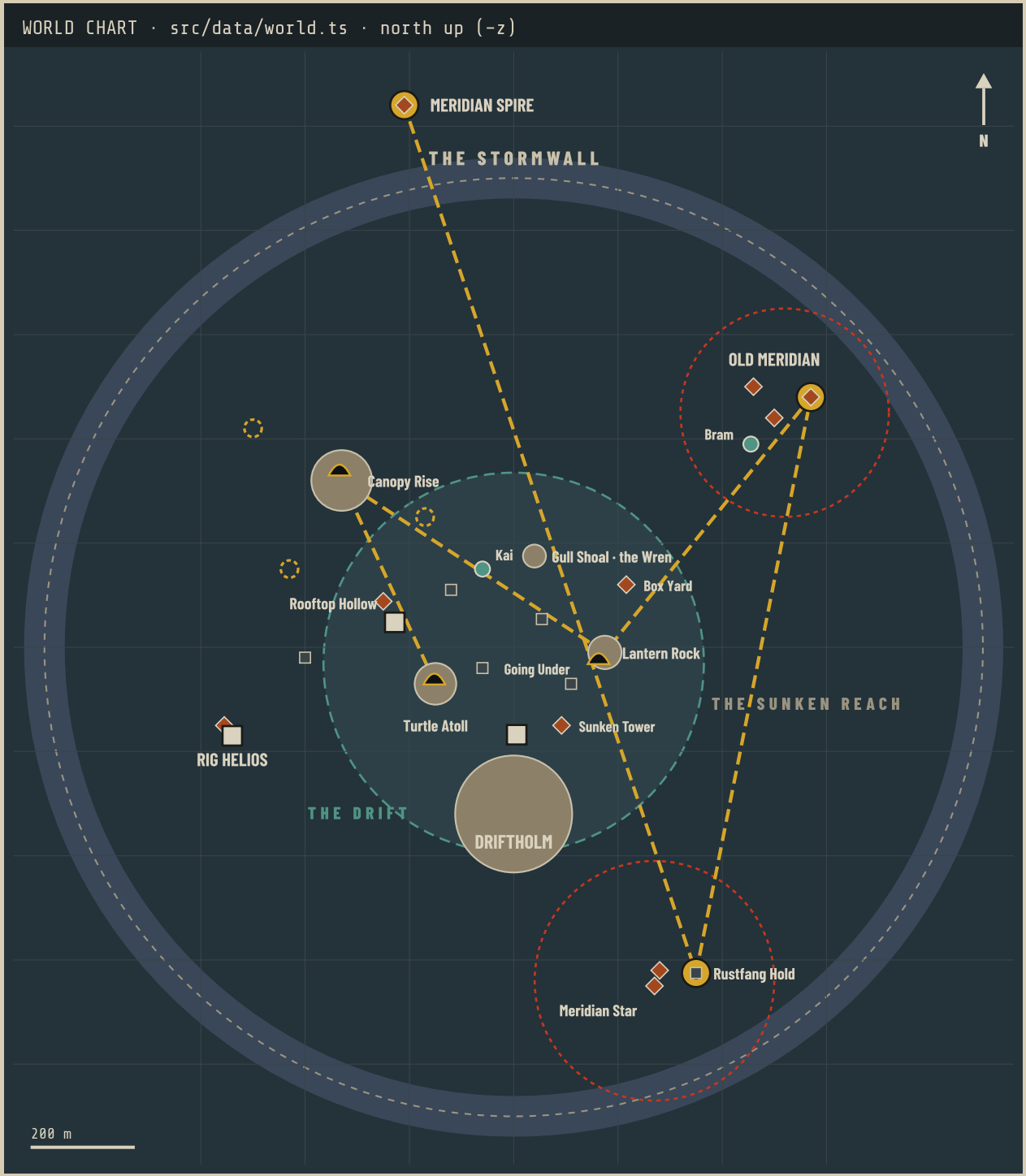
Renown: what the Drift says about you. It is earned from deeds, never bought.

Prize: a raider skiff driven off, or a hulk claimed. Rustfang talks in prizes.

Tidebreaker: a captain who has gone through the Stormwall and come back. This is the title the game is named for.

NEVER

- No skull-and-crossbones as branding. The cheeky menace of the Grinning Sun stays the emblem (creative/art-direction).
- Green is never loot, success or UI. Only living things are green.
- No cartoon gold glitter. Treasure looks salvaged: oil-stained pearls, stopped watches, signet rings.
- No killing. Harpoons drive raiders off (src/game/raiders.ts:218), and the tone stays adventure, not slaughter.



03 · The World

One map

- Settlement with services (3)
- Salvage site (10)
- Outpost, set dressing only (6)
- Walkable island (5)
- Castaway: crew to rescue (2)
- Rustfang raider zone (2)
- PROPOSED Redfinch Line, maps 1-6
- PROPOSED north-west discovery (3)
- PROPOSED sea-cave mouth (3)

THREE REGIONS, THREE HULLS

The Drift

Silted shallows, home and the first legend clues. Reached in the Patchwork Skiff.

`Driftholm · Turtle Atoll · Lantern Rock · Gull Shoal (the Wren) · Sunken Tower · Box Yard · Rooftop Hollow`

The Sunken Reach

Open swell over drowned cities, with trade and raiders. Needs the Scrap Trimaran.

`Old Meridian · Rig Helios · Canopy Rise · Rustfang Graveyard & Hold`

The Stormwall

A storm that never ends, with the Meridian Spire inside it. Needs the Ironwake.

`Meridian Spire › the Last Summit chart`

Positions are the real coordinates from world.ts. Dashed gold marks the proposed Redfinch Line: the six treasure maps in story order.

03 · THE WORLD

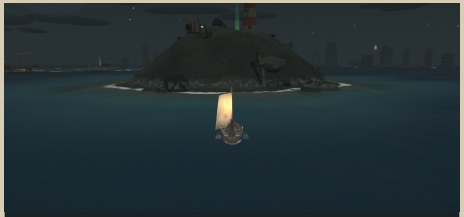
One loop, one legend

The loop the README promises is Explore › discover › salvage › collect › craft › upgrade › explore further. It is mechanically complete. To make it feel like one world, every step of the loop has to hand the player to a person or a place, not just to a menu.



THE LEGEND THAT THREADS THE WORLD

Redfinch is already in the data: a journal page, a chart in two halves and a grand hoard. The proposal makes him the reason the player sails from region to region. **Old Wren**, **Marlo** and **Rustfang** each hold a piece of his story, so the legend lives in people, not menus.



Redfinch

Captain of the trawler Wren and the last captain who tried to reach the Last Summit. EXISTS as the journal page (journal_redfinch), Redfinch's Chart and the Sun Hoard. PROPOSED: the legend that threads all three regions.



The Wren

Redfinch's trawler, wrecked inside the Gull Shoal reef (src/data/world.ts:136). PROPOSED: Old Wren, the cartographer, was her navigator, and the boat was named for her.



The Last Summit

A mountain past the Stormwall that 'never went under' (ui.ts:980). Its chart is the first haul at the Meridian Spire. EXISTS as the end of the Captain's Log, 'To be continued…'.



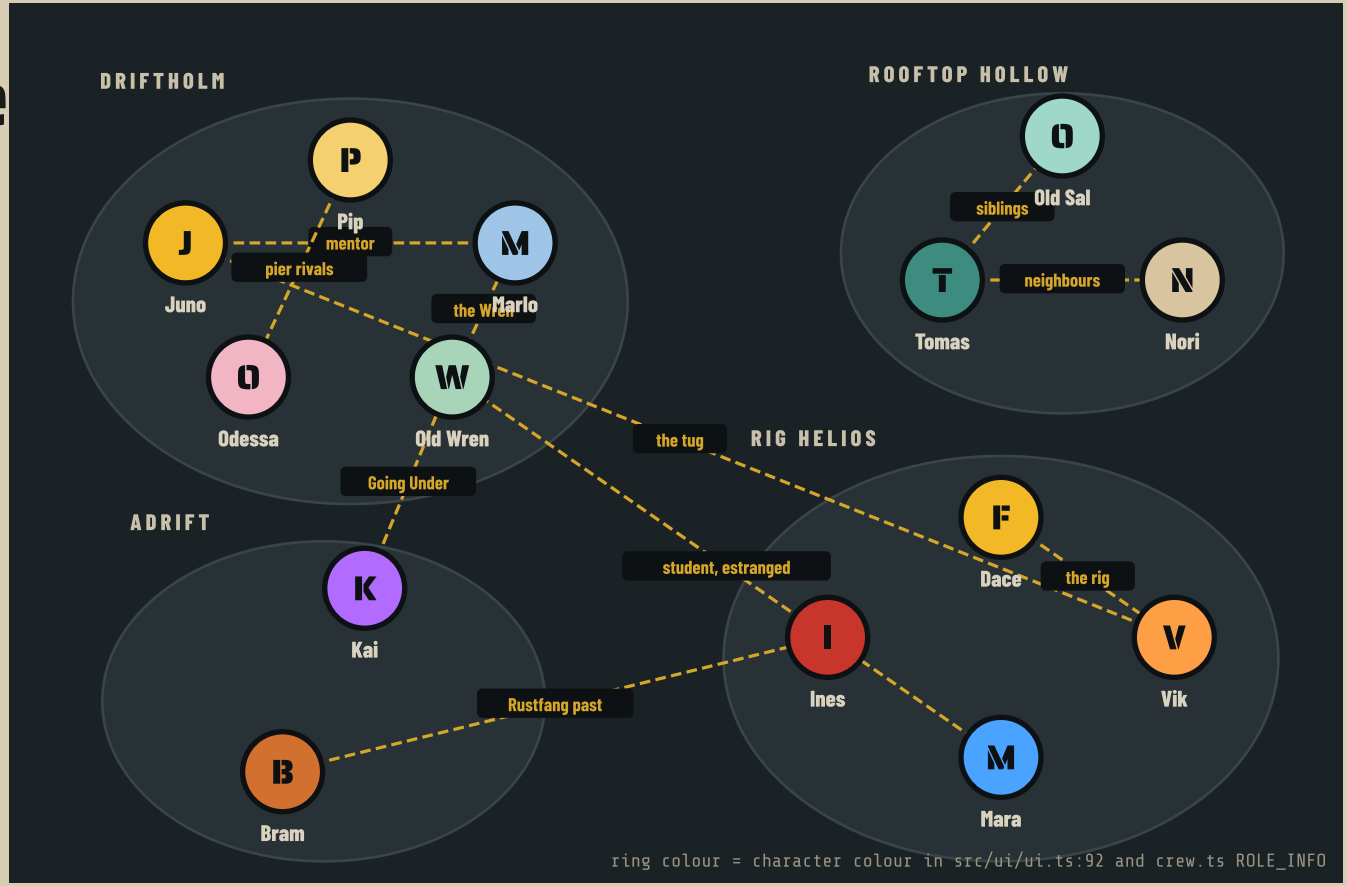
Rustfang

The raiders of the tanker graveyard (Rustfang Hold, Old Meridian waters). PROPOSED: they took Redfinch's last crew and kept what they found.

04 · THE CAST

Fourteen people

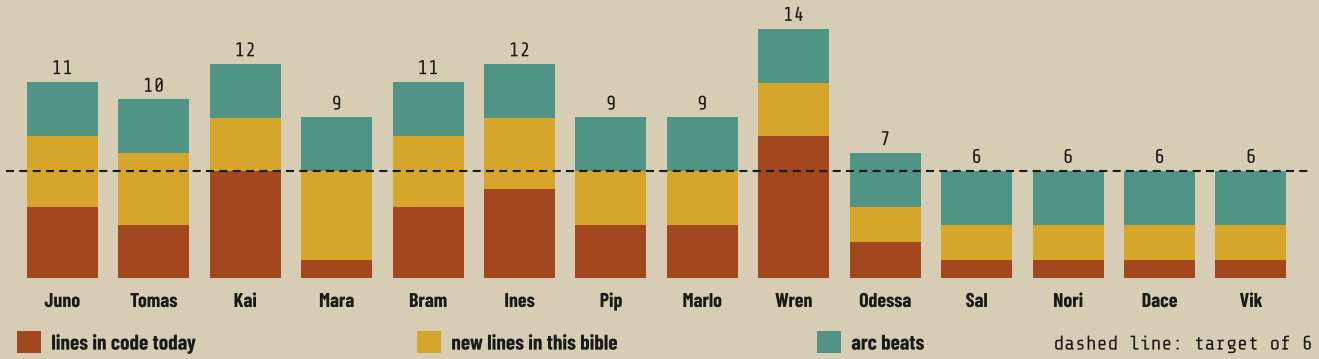
Fourteen named characters exist: six crew who ride on deck with real perks (src/data/crew.ts) and eight settlement NPCs who run services (src/ui/ui.ts:92). Together they have about 40 lines and no story beats. Each sheet keeps the existing facts (role, home, cost, perk, model) and adds a want, a wound, a voice, three arc beats tied to places that already exist, new lines by trigger and one gameplay hook. Pronouns are part of each character's design.



LINES TODAY › TARGET

Every character reaches the target of 6 or more lines plus arc beats. Mara goes from 1 to 9.

Dashed lines on the web are the relationships this bible proposes. They are what makes a meeting in one port pay off in another: the tug (Juno and Vik), the Wren (Old Wren and Marlo), Rustfang (Bram and Ines), the Hollow (Tomas and Sal).



04 · THE CAST

Arcs across the map

Each character gets three beats, and every beat is pinned to a place that already exists. A meeting in the Drift sets up a payoff in the Reach or inside the Stormwall, so sailing somewhere new is also seeing someone again.

RULES FOR BEATS

- A beat needs a place, a trigger (a goal, contract, item or crew pairing) and a visible result (a line, a price, a structure, a perk).
- No beat blocks the Captain's Log. Beats are rewards for wandering.
- Crew beats fire only while that crew member is aboard, which makes choosing a crew an agency choice.
- **NPC beats change their port:** a museum shelf, a raft deck, a second flare.

	DRIFT	REACH	STORMWALL
Juno Vale	1 Signs on after the outboard	2 At Rig Helios she sees Vik Ash...	3 While the Ironwake is being bu...
Tomas Reyes	1 Signs on at the Hollow	2 3 Points out a cold current ...	
Kai	1 2 Rescued on the First Voyag...		3 Kai is the first to see the La...
Mara Okonkwo		1 2 Hired at Helios	3 Back at Driftholm with the sum...
Bram Steele		1 2 3 Rescued in Old Meridian	
Ines Ferro		1 2 3 Hired at Helios once y...	
Pip Farthing	1 First sale on the First Voyage	2 Asks for a Photograph of Dry L...	3 The Driftholm Museum opens on ...
Marlo Keelhart	1 2 Fits your first upgrade		3 The Ironwake launches
Old Wren	1 2 Sends you to Turtle Atoll ...		3 The Chart of the Last Summit i...
Odessa Brightly	1 First cosmetic	2 Wants Helios flare-red dye (a ...	3 Through the Wall, she sews the...
Old Sal	1 Buys anything that floats or s...	2 3 Asks for the 'Songs for Dr...	
Nori Kettle	1 2 Sells Trolling Rods and ge...	3 A new raft deck lashed beside ...	
Foreman Dace		1 2 3 Docking at Helios (mil...	
Vik Ashby		1 2 3 Sells the Reach gear	

Numbered dots = beat order per character. Text = first beat in that region. Full beats are on the character sheets.



Crew models: creative/3d-characters (GITCRAFT MeshCraft). Juno · Tomas · Kai · Mara · Bram · Ines



Mechanic · she/her

Juno Vale

Home: Driftholm · 120g · needs the Salvaged Outboard

Model: tb_crew_mechanic (welding goggles, leather apron, wrench)

EXISTS: Perk: the engine burns 35% less fuel and she slowly repairs the hull at sea. 4 lines: pitch, juno_joined, juno_upgrade, juno_hull.

WANT

To build an engine that never needs fuel. Every solar panel and turbine you fit is a step toward her dream.

WOUND

Her father skippered the Driftholm tug that tows swamped captains home (game.ts:896). The tug's twin diesels went missing three winters ago.

VOICE

Dry, quick, talks to engines like difficult pets. Never says thank you; fixes something instead.

ARC · THREE BEATS

1 **Drift:** Signs on after the outboard. She names your engine and the name shows on the Ship panel.

2 **Reach:** At Rig Helios she sees Vik Ashby's 'Twin Diesel Drive' and goes quiet. 'Those are Dad's.' (see Vik)

3 **Stormwall:** While the Ironwake is being built she welds a plate from her father's tug into the hull. Her hull repair doubles inside the Stormwall.

NEW LINES BY TRIGGER

first engine start: "Hear that cough? That's her saying hello. Be nice to her."

solar_array installed: "Sun in, fuel out. One day we won't need a drop of crude."

docked at Rig Helios: "Don't buy anything off Vik until I've looked at it."

hull below 20% in a storm: "Captain, I can patch her or bail her. Pick one!"

GAMEPLAY HOOK

Juno's Call: when the hull drops below 35% she offers a choice. Spend 1 Engine Parts for an instant +30 hull, or limp home on her slow repair.



Fisher · he/him

Tomas Reyes

Home: Rooftop Hollow · 60g

Model: tb_crew_fisher (white beard, yellow oilskin, sou'wester, gaff)

EXISTS: Perk: catches Silverfin while you sail, 3× with Trolling Rods. 3 lines: pitch, tomas_joined, tomas_catch.

WANT

One last run of fish nobody has caught before. 'Somewhere the fish haven't heard of me.'

WOUND

Forty years on one roof. His sister Old Sal never forgave him for staying when the others left for the Reach.

VOICE

Slow, warm, measures everything in tides and meals. Tells the same three stories, and they get better each time.

ARC · THREE BEATS

1 **Drift:** Signs on at the Hollow. Sal: 'Bring him back fat or don't bring him back.'

2 **Reach:** Points out a cold current off Last Call outpost. A Silverfin run appears there at dawn.

3 **Reach:** At Canopy Rise he kneels in the soil. He asks you to take a Potted Green home to the Hollow roof (the Green Choice).

NEW LINES BY TRIGGER

first Silverfin: "Silverfin on the line. We eat tonight."

sailing past Rooftop Hollow: "Forty years I looked at the sea from up there. It's better from down here."

seeing a living plant: "My mother grew beans in a boot. Real beans. I never believed her."

dawn at sea: "Fish rise at first light. So do fools. We're both."

GAMEPLAY HOOK

Tomas's Run: once a day a 'Silverfin running' marker appears near the boat. A short detour gives a triple catch: a small, optional choice.



Lookout · they/them

Kai

Home: Castaway raft north of Driftholm (cw_kai, -60, -150) · free

Model: tb_crew_lookout (tarp poncho, hood, binoculars)

EXISTS: Perk: warns of storms and raiders, and more drifting caches are spotted. 6 lines: pitch, kai_joined, kai_storm, kai_raiders, kai_green and a storm toast.

WANT

To find out who cut their family's platform loose. Their raft flies a ragged flag.

WOUND

Eleven days alone on that raft. The platform they came from is the one called Going Under (src/data/world.ts:431), sinking slowly in the Drift.

VOICE

Few words, all of them sightings. Counts things. Calls the player 'Captain' a little too formally.

ARC · THREE BEATS

1 **Drift:** Rescued on the First Voyage (Ambitious) or from the Captain's Log (current).

2 **Drift:** Sailing past Going Under: 'That's ours. That was ours.' A cache there opens only when Kai is aboard.

3 **Stormwall:** Kai is the first to see the Last Summit from the Spire: 'Land, Captain. Actual land.'

NEW LINES BY TRIGGER

near Going Under: "That's ours. That was ours. Don't stop. ...No, stop."

night, deck lights on: "You lit us up. Every raider in the Drift can see us now. Good. Let them look."

treasure map complete: "I can see the X from here. Not really. Almost."

GAMEPLAY HOOK

Kai's Glint: Kai marks one optional 'glint' within 300 m, a cache, a castaway or a rumour, and names it. Sailing to it is a choice, not a goal.



Navigator · she/her

Mara Okonkwo

Home: Rig Helios · 250g

Model: tb_crew_navigator (navy coat, headwrap, round glasses, spyglass)

EXISTS: Perk: marks the nearest unsalvaged site and +10% sail speed. 1 line, her pitch. She is the least-written character in the game.

WANT

To draw the part of the map nobody has drawn: the 'Uncharted waters' the game warns about (game.ts:1655).

WOUND

Old Wren taught her to chart, then threw her out of Driftholm for selling a copy of a chart to Rustfang. She has been at Helios since.

VOICE

Precise and proud. Corrects your headings. Laughs only at good maps.

ARC · THREE BEATS

1 **Reach:** Hired at Helios. 'For a share of the haul.' Her share shows in the haul summary.

2 **Reach:** In Old Meridian she finds her old chalk survey marks on the rooftops. Mara's Survey reveals the hidden chest on the Leaning Block.

3 **Stormwall:** Back at Driftholm with the summit chart, she and Old Wren ink it together. Their reconciliation adds a new region outline to the World Chart.

NEW LINES BY TRIGGER

signing on: "I charted every roof in Old Meridian. For a share of the haul I'll chart them for you."

entering Old Meridian: "Third roof left, chalk mark. Mine. Fifteen years old and still right."

docking at Driftholm: "If Wren asks, I'm crew. Just crew."

at the map edge: "Uncharted? Give me a day and a pencil."

salvage site marked: "Nearest unworked site, two points off the bow. You're welcome."

GAMEPLAY HOOK

Mara's Survey: in Old Meridian, sailing through three chalk-marked roofs in any order reveals a one-time cache. It is exploration with a shape, not a waypoint.



Salvager · he/him

Bram Steele

Home: Castaway raft at an Old Meridian lamppost (cw_bram, 455, -390) · free

Model: tb_crew_salvager (big build, wetsuit, steel pauldron, grapple)

EXISTS: Perk: +1 loot roll on every haul and a wider winch window. 4 lines: pitch, bram_joined, bram_salvage, bram_story.

WANT

His boat back. Rustfang took the Gannet and tied him to a lamppost to watch.

WOUND

Knows Rustfang's routes because he paid tribute to them for years. He is ashamed of it.

VOICE

Big, gentle, patient with the winch. Talks to the dead whose things he brings up.

ARC · THREE BEATS

1 **Reach:** Rescued in Old Meridian. 'I know where they keep the good stuff.'

2 **Reach:** He shows the quiet approach to the Graveyard Boxes: raiders don't patrol the north side at dawn.

3 **Reach:** At Rustfang Hold you find the Gannet's nameplate. Bram hangs it on your rail as a trophy, and it fits a trophy slot.

NEW LINES BY TRIGGER

first haul with Bram: "Easy... easy. There. The sea gave something back."

history item hauled: "Somebody lived down there once. Kept this safe, right till the water came."

sighting Rustfang Hold: "That gate's made from my boat. I'd know those rivets anywhere."

dawn near the Graveyard: "North side, now. They're still sleeping it off."

GAMEPLAY HOOK

Bram's Quiet Approach: near the Graveyard at dawn, raiders don't spawn on the north side for 90 seconds. Timing becomes a choice.



Defender · she/her

Ines Ferro

Home: Rig Helios · 300g · needs the Harpoon Turret

Model: tb_crew_defender (mohawk, eyepatch, road-sign pauldron, harpoon)

EXISTS: Perk: raiders think twice and the harpoon reloads twice as fast. 5 lines: pitch, ines_joined, ines_raiders, ines_hit and an 'And stay out!' toast.

WANT

To be the reason a voyage is quiet. She wants a crew who doesn't need her to be cruel.

WOUND

She was Rustfang. The road-sign armour is theirs. She left the night they took Bram's boat.

VOICE

Short, flat, funny by accident. Never shouts. Raiders do the shouting.

ARC · THREE BEATS

1 **Reach:** Hired at Helios once you own a harpoon. 'Show me a harpoon and I'll show you a quiet voyage.'

2 **Reach:** A raider recognises her mid-fight: 'Ferro? You were one of us!' Bram goes silent for a day.

3 **Reach:** At Rustfang Hold she can talk the raiders down (the non-violent option) or hold the line.

NEW LINES BY TRIGGER

raiders sighted: "Hold the wheel steady. I've got the ugly one."

raider driven off: "Hooked. Let them swim home and tell the others."

recognised by a raider: "Was. Past tense. Aim higher."

quiet night at sea: "This. This is what I signed for."

GAMEPLAY HOOK

Ines's Parley: with Ines aboard, a raider encounter can open with a PARLEY action (pay 20% of the hold's value, or 1 trophy) instead of a fight.



stand-in: generic townsfolk

Trader · Appraiser · he/him

Pip Farthing

Home: Driftholm

Model: generic tb_npc_trader (no unique model)

EXISTS: Buys finds and keeps the Catalog record. 3 lines in the harbour and appraiser panels (ui.ts:780, :891).

WANT

A museum of the old world on a dry shelf. The Catalog is his life's work, not yours.

WOUND

Owns one Photograph of Dry Land. He has never admitted he can't tell if it's real.

VOICE

Delighted by everything, haggles like a game, says 'ooh' unironically.

ARC · THREE BEATS

1 **Drift:** First sale on the First Voyage. 'What did the sea give you today?'

2 **Reach:** Asks for a Photograph of Dry Land (polaroid, Meridian Plaza) and pays double: his first contract.

3 **Stormwall:** The Driftholm Museum opens on the pier. Your ten best Catalog finds stand on display, and Pip names the shelf after you.

NEW LINES BY TRIGGER

first living plant shown: "Ooh. Oh. Don't sell me that. I mean it. Don't you dare."

selling a history item: "Someone wrote this. Someone LIVED. Twenty gold. Twenty-five. Fine, thirty."

Catalog at 20: "Twenty discoveries! I'm building you a shelf. A whole shelf!"

GAMEPLAY HOOK

Pip's Wants: Pip always names one wanted item (a category or a specific find) that pays 1.5×. It turns selling into a target.



stand-in: generic townsfolk

Shipwright & Mechanic · he/him

Marlo Keelhart

Home: Driftholm

Model: generic tb_npc_dockhand (no unique model)

EXISTS: Sells and fits upgrades and builds the Trimaran and the Ironwake. 3 lines plus 6 mentions in hints and toasts.

WANT

To build one boat that comes back from the Stormwall.

WOUND

He built the Wren for Redfinch. She never came back, and he hasn't drawn a hull that size since.

VOICE

Gruff, proud, speaks in guarantees. 'Every plate I weld, you'll see.'

ARC · THREE BEATS

1 **Drift:** Fits your first upgrade. 'She looks better already.' (existing reveal card)

2 **Drift:** Commissioning the Trimaran, he unrolls old drawings stamped 'WREN · REDFINCH'.

3 **Stormwall:** The Ironwake launches. 'I built one boat for that wall. She didn't come back. This one will.'

NEW LINES BY TRIGGER

Trimaran commissioned: "Fuel-tank floats. Redfinch would've laughed. Then bought two."

Ironwake commissioned: "Bring me alloy, and bring yourself back. In that order."

swamped and towed home: "I patched the worst of it. The worst of it was your steering."

GAMEPLAY HOOK

Marlo's Yard Board: the Shipwright panel shows the next hull as a blueprint that fills in part by part as materials arrive, a visible goal on the pier.



stand-in: generic townsfolk

Cartographer · Charts & Rumours · she/her

Old Wren

Home: Driftholm

Model: generic tb_npc_elder (lantern, long white hair)

EXISTS: Reads map fragments and tells 4 rumours (ui.ts:977-980), plus a fragment hint and an 'edge of the map' line. She is the best-written NPC, at about 8 lines.

WANT

Someone to finish Redfinch's voyage, and to be forgiven for not going with him.

WOUND

She was the Wren's navigator. The boat was named for her. She stayed ashore the night they sailed for the Stormwall.

VOICE

Riddles that turn out to be instructions. Knows more than she says, and says so.

ARC · THREE BEATS

1 **Drift:** Sends you to Turtle Atoll for the bottle: the reason for the First Voyage (Ambitious).
2 **Drift:** Holding both halves of Redfinch's Chart: 'That's my hand on the left half, captain.'
3 **Stormwall:** The Chart of the Last Summit is in her handwriting. She asks to come aboard for the final voyage (new berth event).

NEW LINES BY TRIGGER

before the First Voyage: "A bottle washed up on Turtle, the gulls say. Bring me what's inside, and don't read it first. Read it first."

Redfinch map complete: "That's my hand on the left half. I drew it for him. I didn't go."

summit chart brought home: "He made it. The stubborn fool made it."

GAMEPLAY HOOK

Wren's Rumour Board: three rumours at a time, each pinnable to the chart as an optional lead. This is the main source of player-chosen goals (see Agency).



art need: unique model

Paint, Sails & Curios · she/her

Odessa Brightly

Home: Driftholm (Brightly's Curios)

Model: none (no NPC model assigned)

EXISTS: Sells paint, sails and flags. 2 lines (ui.ts:791, :999).

WANT

To sew a flag worth being afraid of: the Tidebreaker colours.

WOUND

Lost her own boat to vanity: she painted it gold and Rustfang saw it from three miles away.

VOICE

Theatrical, affectionate insults, calls everyone 'darling'.

ARC · THREE BEATS

1 **Drift:** First cosmetic. 'A boat should look like its captain. Yours looks... damp.'
2 **Reach:** Wants Helios flare-red dye (a Rig Helios contract) and unlocks the Helios Sunburst flag sooner.
3 **Stormwall:** Through the Wall, she sews the Tidebreaker colours, a unique flag shown on every vessel you own.

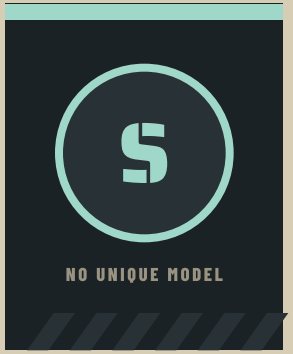
NEW LINES BY TRIGGER

Renown rank up: "They're talking about you on the pier, darling. Let's give them something to point at."

legendary cosmetic earned: "Stormbreaker grey. Finally, a captain I can dress."

GAMEPLAY HOOK

Odessa's Colours: the flag cosmetic gains an emblem layer (Grinning Sun, tidecurl, compass rose, from creative/branding) unlocked by Renown.



art need: unique model

Fish Trader · she/her

Old Sal

Home: Rooftop Hollow
Model: generic townsfolk
EXISTS: Trader at the Hollow. 1 line (ui.ts:781).

WANT

Music. The Hollow hasn't heard a song since the generator died.

WOUND

Tomas's older sister. She stayed to keep the forty fed when everyone young left.

VOICE

Barter in every sentence. Never says no; says 'and?'

ARC · THREE BEATS

1 **Drift:** Buys anything that floats or sinks.
2 **Reach:** Asks for the 'Songs for Dry Days' LP (Hollow Underfloors or the Leaning Block) and the Transistor Radio.
3 **Reach:** The Hollow plays the LP. While docked there, the theme's lead stem plays the melody (src/audio/pack.ts MIX).

NEW LINES BY TRIGGER

docking with Tomas aboard: "You're not fat. Why aren't you fat?"
delivering the LP: "...Turn it up. No. Louder."

GAMEPLAY HOOK

Sal's Swap: the Hollow pays in materials (rope, nails, canvas) instead of gold at a better rate, so each port prices differently.



art need: unique model

Raft-wright · he/him

Nori Kettle

Home: Rooftop Hollow
Model: generic townsfolk
EXISTS: Shipwright at the Hollow (Trolling Rods and basic upgrades). 1 line (ui.ts:784).

WANT

To keep the building standing. The Hollow Underfloors are rotting.

WOUND

Watched the Leaning Block in Old Meridian start to go. Knows the Hollow is next.

VOICE

Practical, young and anxious, explains knots unprompted.

ARC · THREE BEATS

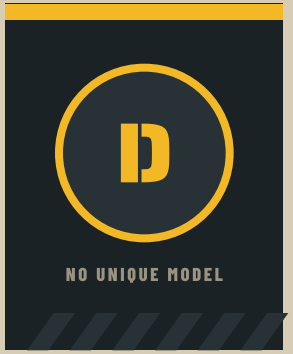
1 **Drift:** Sells Trolling Rods and gear.
2 **Drift:** Contract: 8 Iron Nails and 4 Scrap Metal from the Hollow Underfloors to shore up the stilts.
3 **Reach:** A new raft deck lashed beside the roof is built and visible: the Hollow grows because you helped.

NEW LINES BY TRIGGER

contract complete: "That's three more winters. Maybe four. I'll take four."
Hollow deck built: "Look at that. A floor that floats. Mum would've cried."

GAMEPLAY HOOK

Nori's Lashings: completing Hollow contracts adds visible structures to the settlement, a permanent change in the world.



art need: unique model

Rig Trader · he/him

Foreman Dace

Home: Rig Helios

Model: generic townsfolk

EXISTS: Trader at Helios. 1 line: 'Rig rules: everybody trades, nobody steals. Rustfang excepted.' (ui.ts:782)

WANT

To keep the flare burning. Crude from the Lower Deck is running dry.

WOUND

Pays Rustfang a quiet tribute so they leave the rig alone. 'Rustfang excepted' is a lie.

VOICE

Rules, numbers, a handshake he means. Respects only the paid.

ARC · THREE BEATS

1 **Reach:** Docking at Helios (milestone m_helios): 'Rig rules.'

2 **Reach:** Contract: drive off a Rustfang raider (goal g_raiders) to protect a fuel run, paid in Alloy Plate.

3 **Reach:** If you find his tribute ledger in Rustfang Hold, you choose: confront him (Helios prices up, Rustfang raids stop) or keep his secret (a discount for life).

NEW LINES BY TRIGGER

first sale at Helios: "Fair price. Rig price. Don't argue, it's both."

after g_raiders: "Rustfang excepted. Ha. Not any more, eh?"

GAMEPLAY HOOK

Dace's Fuel Run: a repeatable contract to deliver Crude Oil from the Lower Deck to the flare for Alloy Plate. It opens the Ironwake's material path.



art need: unique model

Rig Mechanic · he/him

Vik Ashby

Home: Rig Helios

Model: generic townsfolk

EXISTS: Sells the Twin Diesel Drive, Salvage Radar and Harpoon Turret. 1 line (ui.ts:785). The diesels are 'pulled from a harbour tug' (ship.ts:113).

WANT

To be the best mechanic in the Reach, which means beating Juno.

WOUND

The 'harbour tug' was Juno's father's. Vik stripped it after the storm and has told himself it was abandoned.

VOICE

Salesman's patter over a mechanic's honesty. Everything is 'proper kit'.

ARC · THREE BEATS

1 **Reach:** Sells the Reach gear: 'Proper kit for the Reach.'

2 **Reach:** With Juno aboard, the Twin Diesel's description changes. Juno confronts him.

3 **Reach:** Vik confesses and offers the diesels at cost, or Juno refuses them and builds her own (a choice: price or principle).

NEW LINES BY TRIGGER

Juno aboard at Helios: "Vale. You look... exactly like him, actually."

confession: "It was drifting. It was. I told myself it was."

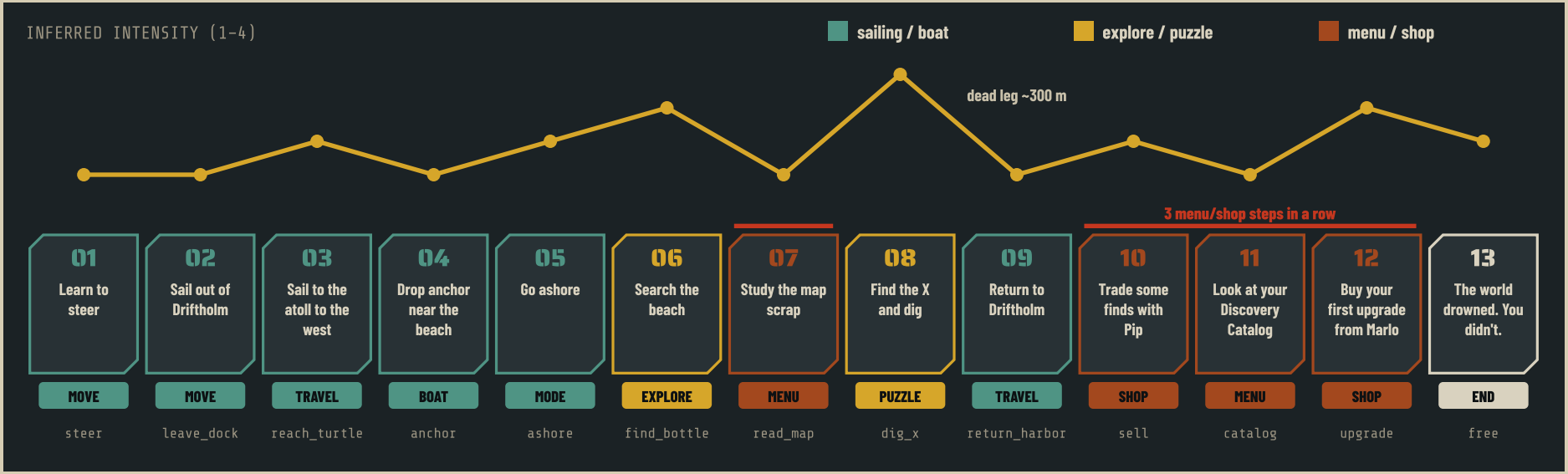
GAMEPLAY HOOK

Vik's Confession: the first branching NPC choice in the game. It changes a price and a crew bark, and it proves choices exist.

05 · THE FIRST VOYAGE

Thirteen steps, measured

FIRST_VOYAGE (src/data/progress.ts:53) is checked step by step in Game.updateQuest (game.ts:2060). The HUD reads "First Voyage · n/12". Kinds and intensity are inferred design judgements.



No salvage

SALVAGE and the winch, the game's signature verbs, first appear as Captain's Log goal 1, after the tutorial (progress.ts:79).

No people until step 10

Pip is the first character the player meets. The crew, the legend and the raiders are all absent.

4 of 12 steps are menus or shops

read_map, catalog, sell and upgrade teach UI, not the world. read_map and dig_x even share one completion check (game.ts:2088-2091).

Zero choices

One route, one order, one upgrade suggestion. Players learn that the game tells them what to do.

A dead return leg

Turtle Atoll to Driftholm is about 300 m of empty sailing at the skiff's 6.5 m/s, with nothing scheduled on the way.

What is great: keep it

The treasure dig. Bottle › map scrap › landmark clue › dig is the best-designed sequence in the game and the purest pirate fantasy. Every proposal keeps it as the centrepiece.

05 · THE FIRST VOYAGE

Three redesigns

All three keep the treasure dig as the centrepiece and keep every QuestStepId, so saves stay valid. Recommended path: ship the Conservative cut in Phase 1, then the Ambitious voyage in Phase 2.



Tighten: 13 › 8 steps

Same route, same content and the same ids. Merge the steps that teach a button and teach menus in context.

GAMEPLAY IMPACT

First free choice arrives about 40% sooner. Every remaining step is a world verb. The winch is taught in the first session.

The Wren's Bottle: a voyage with a reason

The same treasure dig, framed by a person, a salvage, a rescue choice and a choice of first upgrade.

GAMEPLAY IMPACT

The player meets 4 characters, uses all four core verbs (sail, dig, salvage, rescue) and makes 2 real choices before the Log starts. The legend begins on minute 2.

Swamped: the cold open

Start on a raft breaking apart in a storm. Towed into Driftholm by Juno's father's tug, you get a skiff built from your raft's planks. Then pick any 2 of 3 leads in any order.

GAMEPLAY IMPACT

The strongest first image and stakes. Agency from minute 3. The skiff feels earned and personal.

05 · THE FIRST VOYAGE

Implementation & tradeoffs

CONSERVATIVE

Tighten: 13 › 8 steps

IMPLEMENTATION

Edit FIRST_VOYAGE (progress.ts:53). Keep the QuestStepId union intact and map retired ids to the next live step in store.advanceQuest and on load (saves stay valid). Show 'catalog' as a one-time toast on the first discovery. Update tests and play.cjs expectations.

TRADEOFFS

Fewer explicit lessons. Players who never open MAPS on their own need the auto-open. Low risk.

VALIDATE

Steps 13 › 8. PLAYCRAFT time-to-first-choice down by 30% or more. e2e: first voyage completes headless.

AMBITIOUS RECOMMENDED

The Wren's Bottle: a voyage with a reason

IMPLEMENTATION

Add an optional `branch` to QuestStep ({id, optional?: true, skipWhen?}). Wren's intro uses the existing revealInfo card. Inline rescue reuses CASTAWAYS cw_kai. The salvage reuses sv_stump. The starter choice is a one-time harbor sheet with three upgrade cards and a price multiplier. Move GOALS g_salvage/ g_crew to auto-complete if done in the voyage (they already check state).

TRADEOFFS

Longer first session (about 9 to 12 minutes, against about 7 now) but with denser content. More branching to test. The starter discount changes early economy slightly.

VALIDATE

4 characters met and 2 choices made in the voyage. Story density in the first third ≥ 3 beats (STORYCRAFT). Retention proxy: PLAYCRAFT session continues past the voyage.

WILD CARD

Swamped: the cold open

IMPLEMENTATION

A new prologue scene (raft model, scripted storm), a non-linear voyage (set-based completion) and a save flag. Prototype behind ?wild=swamped.

TRADEOFFS

Starting with danger before control can lose touch-screen players. It costs the most art and tuning, and it competes with the calm-sea title screen.

VALIDATE

A/B against the Conservative voyage: prologue completion ≥ 90%, first-session length and replays.

06 · AGENCY & EXPLORATION

Offer leads, not orders

Agency scores 0.5 / 10. The Captain's Log is a good spine but a single road. The world is full of places the player could choose between, but nothing offers them a choice. The fix is to offer leads, let the player pick, and make picks change something they can see.

CONSERVATIVE

Two Roads & Rumour Pins

The Captain's Log always shows the main goal plus one side lead. Wren's rumours become pins.

CHANGES

- **Log card gains a second line:** one SIDE LEAD drawn from the open castaways, incomplete maps, unworked salvage sites and rumours. Tap to swap which one the marker follows.
- Wren's 4 rumours (ui.ts:977) become RumourDefs with a target. 'Pin it' puts a lead on the World Chart.
- Fill the empty north-west (6 of 9 cells empty) with 3 small discoveries on routes players already sail: a bell buoy, a drowned billboard and a lashed shrine, each with one line of lore and one find.

GAMEPLAY IMPACT

Every session starts with a choice between two goals. Empty sea becomes a string of small promises.

IMPLEMENTATION

New src/data/rumours.ts (RumourDef). GOALS unchanged. updateGuidance gets a 'followSide' toggle. Three new POIS and small finds in world.ts. One new save field: pinned: string[ ].

TRADEOFFS

Two markers can confuse a new player, so show the side lead only after the First Voyage.

VALIDATE

Agency criterion ≥ 3 / 10 in the DESIGNCRAFT re-run. Empty cells 19 › ≤ 16. Playtest: sessions in which the player chose the side lead ≥ 40%.

AMBITIOUS RECOMMENDED

Contracts, Renown & the Green Choice

Every NPC posts contracts. Ports remember what you did. Living plants pose the game's central choice.

CHANGES

- **CONTRACTS:** each of the 8 NPCs offers 1 to 3 contracts at a time (deliver, salvage, rescue, escort, survey, donate). Each has a giver, a target place, a reward and an arc beat. Examples: Nori's nails, Sal's LP, Dace's Fuel Run, Pip's Photograph.
- RENOWN per port (Driftholm, Hollow, Helios): contracts raise it, and ranks unlock prices, crew lines and visible growth (Nori's raft deck, Pip's Museum, a second flare at Helios).
- **THE GREEN CHOICE:** a living plant can be SOLD (gold), DONATED to the Driftholm garden (the garden visibly grows on the hill, and fresh food raises crew perks by 10%), or CARRIED to the Hollow roof (Tomas's beat). It is the moral spine of the game and needs no violence.

GAMEPLAY IMPACT

Turns 14 characters into reasons to sail, gives every port a living state and makes 'green means alive' a decision as well as a colour.

IMPLEMENTATION

New src/data/contracts.ts (ContractDef), renown in the save (renown: Record<settlementId, number>), garden stages in drowned.ts keyed on donations, and a harbor-panel 'Board' tab. It reuses the existing salvage, castaway and map completion checks as contract conditions.

TRADEOFFS

Large surface area: about 24 contracts to write and balance. Selling plants versus donating them must be balanced so neither is obviously right.

VALIDATE

Mission design rises from 0 (untested) to ≥ 8 / 15. Choices with consequences ≥ 3. Playtest: split of donate versus sell between 30/70 and 70/30.

WILD CARD

Letters of Marque

Pick a side in the Reach. Privateer for Helios against Rustfang supply skiffs, or pay Rustfang and sail untouched.

CHANGES

- At Renown 2 with Helios, Dace offers a Letter of Marque. At Rustfang Hold, the raiders offer the Rust Token.
- **Privateer:** raider skiffs carry prize cargo and their driven-off skiffs drop it. Helios prices drop, and raiders hunt you harder.
- **Rust Token:** raider zones go quiet, Helios prices rise, Ines leaves the crew (or confronts you).

GAMEPLAY IMPACT

The most 'pirate' choice possible, with consequences for crew, prices and the map.

IMPLEMENTATION

Faction state, raider behaviour branches in raiders.ts, a crew-leave event and two new items. Prototype behind ?wild=marque.

TRADEOFFS

Risks a darker tone than 'cheeky menace'. Crew leaving can feel punitive. It needs careful balance with g_raiders.

VALIDATE

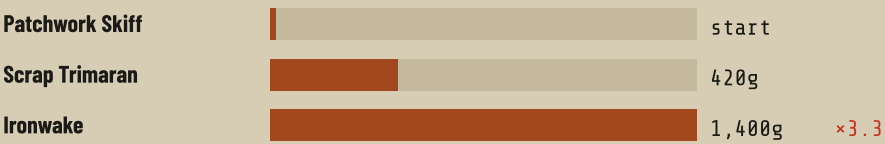
Playtest: perceived freedom rating, a 50/50-ish faction split, and no softlock of g_raiders.

07 · DINGHY TO PIRATE SHIP

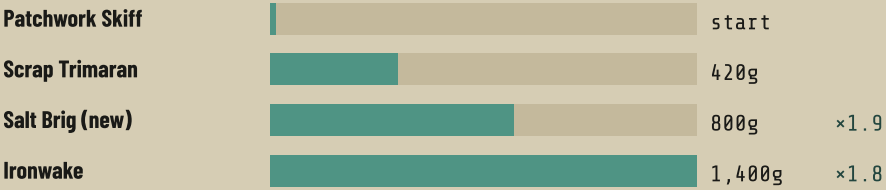
Eight planks to a flagship

The boat is the game, and the code already proves it: every upgrade is a visible model (ship/shipModel.ts). The ladder has three rungs: Patchwork Skiff (whose id is literally 'dinghy'), Scrap Trimaran and Ironwake. Between rungs the price jumps 420 › 1,400 gold (3.3×), and nothing on the boat tells the player who they are becoming. The original art direction drew this as a four-ship arc, leaky dinghy › sloop › brig › grand Tidebreaker (creative/ships). The fantasy is there; the middle rung is missing.

TODAY: 3 hulls

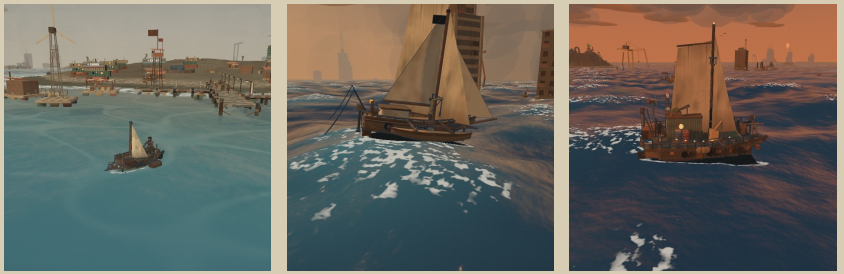


AMBITIOUS: 4 hulls (Salt Brig)

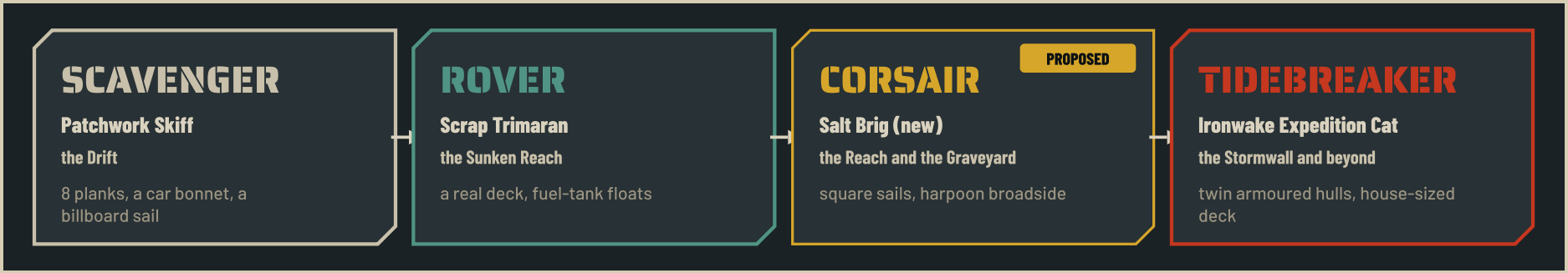


THE NUMBERS (src/data/ship.ts, world.ts, progress.ts)

Upgrades	19 upgrades cost 2,630 gold in total, plus materials
Vessels	Trimaran 420g + 21 mats · Ironwake 1,400g + 24 mats
Guaranteed income	Captain's Log 880g + milestones 1,325g + 2 treasure maps ~1,080g + placed finds ~2,270g
Salvage EV / haul	Drift 23–42g · Reach 42–183g · Spire 353g (respawn 4–15 min)
Cost jump	Skiff › Trimaran: 420g · Trimaran › Ironwake: 1,400g (3.3×)



In-game today: Patchwork Skiff · Scrap Trimaran · Ironwake (all upgrades)



Renown ranks are proposed (Conservative tier). The Corsair rung exists only in the Ambitious tier. A rank is earned from deeds and milestones, never bought.

07 · DINGHY TO PIRATE SHIP

Three ladders

CONSERVATIVE

Refit Stages, Renown & a Name

No new hulls. Make the existing ladder read as becoming a pirate captain.

CHANGES

- **REFIT STAGES:** each hull has three visible stages (Stripped, Rigged, Fitted Out), computed from upgrades installed on it. Rigged adds rope fenders and a pennant. Fitted Out adds a figurehead and a lantern.
- **NAME HER:** at the first upgrade, name the boat. The name shows on the stern, in Marlo's lines and in the Log.
- **RENOWN TITLES:** Scavenger › Rover › Tidebreaker, from milestones and goals already in progress.ts, shown on the Ship panel with Odessa's new flag emblems.

GAMEPLAY IMPACT

Progress you can see on every rung, plus identity: 'Captain of the Gull's Folly, Rover of the Reach'.

IMPLEMENTATION

RefitStage table in ship.ts (data). shipModel.ts adds 4 small kit props (tb_boat_kit already has the fittings pipeline). Save fields shipName and renown. The UI touches only the Ship panel.

TRADEOFFS

Cosmetic. It doesn't fix the 3.3× price gap.

VALIDATE

Playtest: players can name their rank. The Ship panel shows a stage change at least once per region.

AMBITIOUS RECOMMENDED

The Salt Brig: the missing rung

Add a fourth hull between the Trimaran and the Ironwake: a square-rigged brig built from Rustfang prize parts. It is the pirate ship of the game.

CHANGES

- NEW VESSEL 'brig' (Salt Brig): speed 11.5, cargo 18, berths 3, hull 130, crossSwell true, crossStorm false. Cost 800g + Canvas 6 + Rope 6 + Alloy Plate 3 + the Gannet's Bell (prize).
- **BROADSIDE:** two harpoon mounts (port and starboard), so driving off raiders becomes positioning.
- Built at Rig Helios by Vik, or by Juno if you chose principle in the Vik arc.
- **Smooths the jump:** 420 › 800 › 1,400 (×1.9, ×1.75).

GAMEPLAY IMPACT

The game finally has the pirate-ship moment, square sails over the Graveyard, at the emotional middle of the campaign.

IMPLEMENTATION

VesselId union + VESSELS entry (ship.ts:84). A new hull model via the GITCRAFT MeshCraft pipeline (creative/3d-*), shipModel slots for broadside, a GOALS entry between g_raiders and g_ironwake, and tests for slot/upgrade compatibility. Saves need no migration (new id only).

TRADEOFFS

One more hull to model, rig, balance and test on mobile performance. It lengthens the Reach chapter by about 30 to 45 minutes.

VALIDATE

Price-step ratio ≤ 2×. PLAYCRAFT: the Reach chapter has no grind plateau over 15 min. Playtest: 'the brig felt like a pirate ship' ≥ 70%.

WILD CARD

Take Her: claim the Ironwake

The Ironwake isn't bought. Its hull is Rustfang's hulk, chained inside the Hold. You take it, and Marlo makes it yours.

CHANGES

- The Ironwake hull lies in Rustfang Hold. Bram knows the back way, and Ines can parley.
- **A raid night:** drive off 3 skiffs (or parley), winch the chain (salvage), tow her out.
- Marlo's refit still costs materials but only 600g. The Ironwake is now a prize with a story.

GAMEPLAY IMPACT

Ship acquisition becomes the campaign's set-piece heist, the purest pirate beat in the game.

IMPLEMENTATION

A scripted event at op_hold, with a tow state on the boat, a new goal replacing g_ironwake's purchase, and a ?wild=takeher flag. The Ironwake model is reused.

TRADEOFFS

Scripted set-pieces are expensive and fragile on mobile. It removes a pure 'save up' goal some players enjoy.

VALIDATE

Playtest set-piece completion ≥ 85%, and the 'most memorable moment' survey.

08 · ISLANDS, PORTS, CAVES & TREASURE

The One-World audit

The One-World rule: every place you can reach has (1) a person who talks about it, (2) one find only it has, (3) a boat capability that opens it and (4) a reason to come back. The table audits every existing place against the rule. Gaps are in rust; proposals that fill them are in brackets.

PLACE	WHO TALKS ABOUT IT	ONLY HERE	OPENED BY	REASON TO RETURN
Driftholm	Pip, Marlo, Wren, Odessa	the vault	start	home, trade, refit · [garden, museum]
Turtle Atoll	Wren (rumour)	Turtle's Belly chest, seedling tin	skiff	**GAP**: [sea cave: the Belly]
Lantern Rock	Wren (rumour)	keeper's sea-chest, live moss	Barnacled Key	**GAP**: [night cave, needs deck lights]
Gull Shoal · the Wren	Wren (rumour)	Redfinch's Chart (left)	copper hull	**GAP**: [Wren's colours, Old Wren beat]
Sunken Tower	Log goal 1	transistor radio	none	respawn 4 min
Box Yard	**nobody**	electronics	none	**GAP**: [Pip contract]
Rooftop Hollow	Sal, Nori	Hollow Underfloors dive	none	trade · [Nori deck, Sal's LP]
Old Meridian	Bram (castaway)	street sign, polaroid	trimaran	[Mara's Survey]
Rig Helios	Dace, Vik	rig badge, crude	trimaran	Reach gear · [fuel run, brig yard]
Canopy Rise	**nobody**	all rare/epic/legendary green	trimaran	**GAP**: [Green Choice, waterfall cave]
Rustfang Hold	**nobody**	**nothing (dressing only)**	trimaran	**GAP**: [Gannet, ledger, Take Her]
Meridian Spire	Log goal 9	Chart of the Last Summit	Ironwake	[Wren finale, Summit]
Outposts ×5	**nobody**	**nothing**	none	**GAP**: [Kai: Going Under · Tomas: Last Call]

08 · TREASURE

The Redfinch Line

Two treasure maps exist. Both are excellent, and both already belong to one story: Redfinch. The Redfinch Line turns them into a six-map saga that crosses every region, where each map needs a different boat capability. Exploring the world becomes reading a legend.



EVERY UPGRADE OPENS A PLACE

A part on the boat should never be just a stat. Each key upgrade opens a place, brings a person and pays off a piece of the legend. Two rows are new: String Lights gain a job (night caves), and the Container Cabin fills the berths for a full crew of six.

Implementation: no new upgrade ids are needed for Phase 1. The cave glint check reads the existing light effect (UpgradeEffects.light). The Broadcast Cache reuses heavy-site salvage (salvage tier 1).

Gold rows are proposed. All others exist and are cited in src/data/ship.ts.

UPGRADE / HULL		OPENS	PERSON · PAYOFF
Canvas Mainsail	→	speed for the dead return leg	**Marlo** faster legend runs
Copper-Banded Hull	→	Gull Shoal reef	**Wren** the Wren wreck, chart left half
Salvaged Outboard	→	Juno signs on	**Juno** windless travel, fuel economy
Brass Compass	→	points to the active map's X	**Wren** every treasure map
String Lights	→	night caves glint (new)	**Kai** Keeper's Light, cave caches
Salvage Crane	→	heavy sites (Rig, Tanker, Spire)	**Bram** Broadcast Cache, Gannet
Harpoon Turret	→	Ines signs on, raiders	**Ines** Rustfang Hold, parley
Container Cabin	→	+2 berths, aboard workbench	**Mara** a full crew of six
Scrap Trimaran	→	the open swell	**Marlo** the Reach, Helios, Canopy
Ironwake	→	the Stormwall	**Marlo, Juno** the Spire, the Summit

08 · CAVES

The missing room

The game has no caves, but its clues already describe them: 'Dig where the turtle keeps its lunch.' Caves are the treasure-island fantasy's missing room.

CONSERVATIVE

Cave Mouths as Dig Sites

Three sea-cave mouths on existing islands, each a lit, shallow dig site. No interiors.

CHANGES

- New LandmarkType 'cave' (world.ts:5) on Turtle Atoll ('the Belly', which fits the existing clue), Lantern Rock (the smugglers' undercut) and Canopy Rise (behind the existing waterfall landmark).
- Each cave holds one cache that glints only at night with String Lights & Spotlight (deck_lights), which gives the lighting slot gameplay for the first time.

GAMEPLAY IMPACT

The lighting upgrade becomes a key. The night cycle gets a reason. The treasure fantasy gains a set-piece.

IMPLEMENTATION

Landmark + cache data, one cave-mouth model from GITCRAFT MeshCraft (tb_landmark_kit), and a light check in the cache-glint code. 1 PR.

TRADEOFFS

Not real caves: the expectation of going inside may disappoint.

VALIDATE

Deck lights purchase rate up. 3 new discoveries in the Catalog.

AMBITIOUS

Drowned Interiors

Two walkable interiors using the existing on-foot mode: the Hollow Underfloors and the belly of the tanker Meridian Star.

CHANGES

- Enter from SALVAGE sites (sv_hollow_sub, sv_tanker): a short on-foot interior with 3 to 5 search points and one story find.
- The tanker belly connects to Rustfang Hold: Bram's back way.

GAMEPLAY IMPACT

Real dungeon-like spaces with darkness, echo and a reward that matters.

IMPLEMENTATION

A new scene type in the game loop (interior), a camera mode, two GITCRAFT interior kits and audio reverb.

TRADEOFFS

Biggest technical cost in this bible. Needs a mobile performance budget.

VALIDATE

PLAYCRAFT interior frame time ≤ 20 ms on iPhone 13 profile. Completion ≥ 80%.

WILD CARD

Tide Caves

A tide cycle tied to the day clock. Some caves open only at low tide (dawn and dusk) and flood at high tide.

CHANGES

- Tide height drives ocean.ts level offset ±0.6 m. Three caves are tide-gated. A Tide Table becomes a navigation upgrade.

GAMEPLAY IMPACT

Time becomes a resource. Planning a voyage gains a new axis.

IMPLEMENTATION

Global water-level offset (ocean, terrain wading checks, anchor depth). High systemic risk.

TRADEOFFS

Touches every water check in the game. Prototype only.

VALIDATE

No regressions in e2e. Playtest comprehension of tide timing ≥ 70%.





Turtle Atoll, where the Belly cave mouth would sit · Lantern Rock at night with String Lights (both captured from the current build)

09 · GAMEPLAY EXAMPLE · THE WREN'S BOTTLE (AMBITIOUS VOYAGE)

Minutes 0–12

0:00 Title orbit over Driftholm. SET SAIL. Old Wren at the pier, lantern up: 'A bottle washed up on Turtle…'

> character · motivation

0:40 Drag the wheel; cast off north. Gulls. A drifting algae mat: 'Ease off to pick through it.' 2 Algae Mats.

> steer · flotsam

1:30 Turtle Atoll rises, a dead coral ring. ANCHOR prompts in the turquoise. GO ASHORE.

> anchor · ashore

2:30 A glint on the south beach: the bottle. The map scrap opens itself: 'Stand between the grinning skull and the two sisters…'

> explore · clue

4:00 Shovel rings loose sand. The chest: doubloons, a pearl, the Turtle Idol. The lid is scratched 'R.F.'

> dig · legend seed

5:30 Back aboard. The radar blips: a raft with a ragged flag. Kai waves both arms. RESCUE (+60 s) or press on?

> choice 1

7:00 The Sunken Tower looms. SALVAGE. The winch: three green-zone hits. Transistor Radio and scrap.

> salvage · winch

9:00 Driftholm. Pip: 'Ooh!' Sell the idol. Marlo lays out three parts: sail, rudder or crate. Pick one.

> trade · choice 2

11:00 Wren turns the lid over: 'R.F. Redfinch. So he did come this way.' The Log opens on two leads.

> legend · agency



WHAT THIS PROVES

Every row is a real system in the build (sail, flotsam, anchor, dig, salvage, castaway, trade, upgrade, raiders) or a proposal from this bible (contracts, the Green Choice, Renown, Mara's Survey, arcs).

BEATS TOUCHED

agency · anchor · ashore · character · choice 1 · choice 2 · clue · dig · explore · flotsam · legend · legend seed · motivation · salvage · steer · trade · winch

09 · GAMEPLAY EXAMPLE · AN EVENING IN THE REACH (PHASE 2 SYSTEMS)

Hour 3

18:40 The Trimaran (named Gull's Folly) leaves Helios with Dace's Fuel Run contract: 6 crude to the flare.

> contract

18:55 Mara: 'Third roof left, chalk mark. Mine.' A survey shape appears over Old Meridian. Detour or deliver?

> choice · character

19:10 Kai: 'Rustfang skiffs! Coming in hard!' Ines on the harpoon. A raider yells 'Ferro?!' Bram goes quiet.

> combat · arc beat

19:30 Third chalk roof: a cache with the Photograph of Dry Land, Pip's wanted item.

> exploration payoff

19:50 Dusk at the flare. Dace pays in Alloy Plate. Renown Helios 2: Vik offers the Salt Brig yard.

> renown · progression

20:05 Tomas spots soil in the hold's manifest: the Potted Green from Canopy. Sell at Helios for 130g, or carry it home?

> the Green Choice



WHAT THIS PROVES

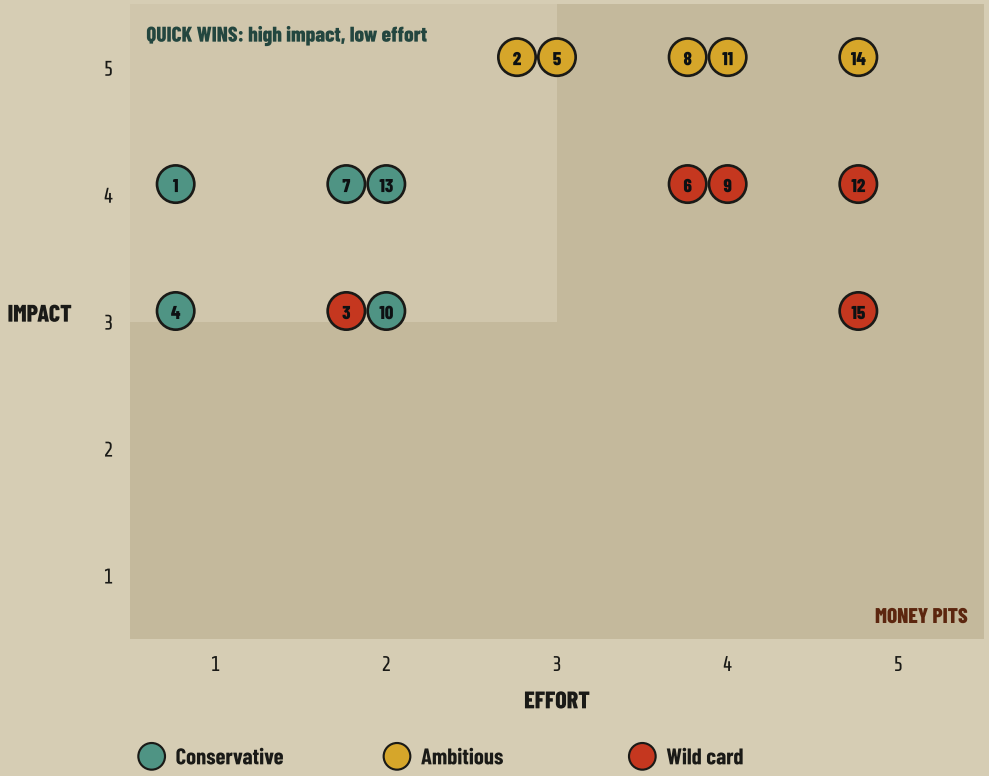
Every row is a real system in the build (sail, flotsam, anchor, dig, salvage, castaway, trade, upgrade, raiders) or a proposal from this bible (contracts, the Green Choice, Renown, Mara's Survey, arcs).

BEATS TOUCHED

arc beat · character · choice · combat · contract · exploration payoff · progression · renown · the Green Choice

10 · ROADMAP

Fifteen proposals, ranked



#	AREA	PROPOSAL	PLAN
1	**Characters** C	Voices for all 14 (≥ 6 lines each) `impact 4 · effort 1 · risk low`	**Phase 1**
2	**Characters** A	Three-beat arcs + Vik/Juno choice `impact 5 · effort 3 · risk med`	**Phase 2 · rec.**
3	**Characters** W	Old Wren joins the final voyage `impact 3 · effort 2 · risk low`	**Phase 3**
4	**First Voyage** C	Tighten 13 › 8 `impact 3 · effort 1 · risk low`	**Phase 1**
5	**First Voyage** A	The Wren's Bottle `impact 5 · effort 3 · risk med`	**Phase 2 · rec.**
6	**First Voyage** W	Swamped cold open `impact 4 · effort 4 · risk high`	**Prototype**
7	**Agency** C	Two Roads & Rumour Pins `impact 4 · effort 2 · risk low`	**Phase 1**
8	**Agency** A	Contracts, Renown, Green Choice `impact 5 · effort 4 · risk med`	**Phase 2 · rec.**
9	**Agency** W	Letters of Marque `impact 4 · effort 4 · risk high`	**Prototype**
10	**Progression** C	Refit stages, Renown, Name her `impact 3 · effort 2 · risk low`	**Phase 1**
11	**Progression** A	The Salt Brig `impact 5 · effort 4 · risk med`	**Phase 2 · rec.**
12	**Progression** W	Take Her (Ironwake heist) `impact 4 · effort 5 · risk high`	**Prototype**
13	**Places** C	Cave mouths + Redfinch maps 3 `impact 4 · effort 2 · risk low`	**Phase 1**
14	**Places** A	Redfinch Line 4–5 + interiors `impact 5 · effort 5 · risk high`	**Phase 2 (maps) · rec.**
15	**Places** W	Tide caves `impact 3 · effort 5 · risk high`	**Prototype**

10 · ROADMAP

Three phases, measured

Phase 1 · Voices & Shape

Conservative tier, 5 PRs, data and copy first

- PR 1.1 Characters: src/data/characters.ts with 14 CharacterDefs, lines by trigger, wired to say()/toast. Every character ≥ 6 lines.
- PR 1.2 First Voyage 13 › 8 with retired-id migration.
- PR 1.3 Two Roads Log + rumours.ts + 3 north-west discoveries.
- PR 1.4 Refit stages, ship name, Renown titles on the Ship panel.
- PR 1.5 Cave mouths ×3 (deck-lights glint) + treasure map 3, The Keeper's Light.

Phase 2 · The Living Adventure

Ambitious items marked RECOMMENDED

- PR 2.1 The Wren's Bottle voyage (replaces 1.2's list; keeps its migration).
- PR 2.2 Contracts + port Renown + the Green Choice (Driftholm garden stages).
- PR 2.3 Character arcs: beats wired to contracts and places; Vik/Juno choice.
- PR 2.4 The Redfinch Line maps 4–5 + the Gannet + Dace's ledger.
- PR 2.5 The Salt Brig (MeshCraft hull, broadside, goal).

Phase 3 · Wild Cards

Prototypes behind ?wild= flags, one at a time

- ?wild=swamped, ?wild=marque, ?wild=takeher, ?wild=tides: each ships only after a playtest beats its Conservative counterpart.

ACCEPTANCE: THE PASS IS DONE WHEN

MEASURE	TARGET	TODAY
Characters	14 / 14 with ≥ 6 lines and ≥ 2 beats	0 / 14 with ≥ 2 beats; Mara has 1 line
First Voyage	≤ 8 steps (P1) · 4 characters + 2 choices (P2)	13 steps, 0 choices, 1 character
Agency (DESIGNCRAFT)	≥ 5 / 10	0.5 / 10
Narrative (DESIGNCRAFT)	≥ 9 / 15	2.6 / 15
Mission design (DESIGNCRAFT)	≥ 8 / 15 (contracts measured)	0 / 15 (untested)
Empty map cells	≤ 16 / 36	19 / 36
Price step between hulls	≤ 2×	3.3×
Places obeying the One-World rule	13 / 13	4 / 13

10 · FOR THE IMPLEMENTATION PASS

Schemas & guardrails

```
// src/data/characters.ts (new)
export type LineTrigger =
  | 'meet' | 'join' | 'dock' | 'storm' | 'raiders' | 'haul' | 'green'
  | 'upgrade' | 'region' | 'night' | 'contract' | 'beat';
export interface CharacterLine { trigger: LineTrigger; when?: string; text: string; voice?: VoiceId
}
export interface ArcBeat { id: string; region: RegionId; place: string; requires: string; text:
string; reward?: string }
export interface CharacterDef {
  id: string; name: string; pronouns: string; kind: 'crew' | 'npc';
  home: string; want: string; wound: string; voice: string;
  lines: CharacterLine[]; arc: ArcBeat[]; hook: string;
}
// src/data/contracts.ts (new, Phase 2)
export interface ContractDef {
  id: string; giver: string; settlement: string;
  kind: 'deliver' | 'salvage' | 'rescue' | 'escort' | 'survey' | 'donate';
  target: { item?: string; n?: number; site?: string; place?: { x: number; z: number } };
  reward: { gold?: number; mats?: { id: string; n: number }[]; renown: number };
  beat?: string; // ArcBeat id this contract advances
}
// save (store.ts): v2 -> v3 adds  shipName, renown, pinned, contracts, beats, garden
```

GUARDRAILS

- Never rename or delete an existing id (items, upgrades, vessels, goals, quest steps, sites). Add, alias, migrate.
- Saves: bump to v3 with a forward migration and a test, like the v1 › v2 migration in store.ts.
- Green stays reserved for living things, and the existing unit test must still pass.
- Every new upgrade or vessel is visible on the boat (the README's core promise).
- Mobile first: 44 px touch targets, ≥ 12 px text, iPhone SE and 13 profiles (PIXELCRAFT pass rules).
- New characters' lines go in data, not in UI code. VOICE_LINES audio is optional; text toasts are required.
- Every PR: npm test, npm run build, tests/e2e/play.cjs, and a live preview link in the PR.

SOURCE FILES

creative/design-bible/WORLD_AND_VOYAGE_BIBLE.md is the same content as text: read it first. source/content.py is the single source of truth. art.py draws the diagrams from the game data. build.py lays out this PDF in DesignCraft.



THE WORLD DROWNED. YOU DIDN'T.

Follow the wake.

Method: a full read of the repository at commit 5766ca5 (src/data, src/game, src/ui, src/audio, docs/). DESIGNCRAFT 1.0 assessment for the measured baseline (25 / 100, ceiling 85). PLAYCRAFT run 20261105001617 imported as simulated evidence. Fresh frames captured from the built game with ?ship= preview links, plus crew renders from docs/characters-pass.

Made with GITCRAFT DesignCraft (layout, vector diagrams, PDF). Typefaces: the game's own Saira Stencil One, Barlow, Barlow Condensed and Share Tech Mono (OFL).

v1.0 · 2026-11-05 · assessed at commit 5766ca5